

Milo Madolora

Professor Harris

Writing 1

14 July, 2024

Sonic Freedom: Kanye West's Ghost Town

In a 2013 interview with New York Times writer Jon Caramanica, musician Kanye West stated “I don’t have some type of romantic relationship with the public. I’m like, the anti-celebrity, and my music comes from a place of being anti.” This sentiment takes sonic form in Kanye’s song “Ghost Town,” a powerful ballad proclaiming the true meaning of freedom. Found on the 2018 album, *ye*, Kanye’s “Ghost Town” evokes thoughts of returning to youth and resting without burdens, discussing the pursuit of freedom and what it means to be free to the individual soul. Using multiple artists, a nostalgic soul sample, and a chilling guitar track, Kanye expresses what freedom means.

Foremost, to truly understand the meaning and weight of the song “Ghost Town,” understanding the artist Kanye West is required. Often known for his controversial antics and outspoken speech, “Ghost Town” serves as an exploration of his mental health and bipolar issues. When the song was recorded, Kanye was mired in multiple controversies, including being a Trump supporter, false claims about slavery, and refusal of medication. Fans and the general public saw these outlandish words as a manifestation of his mental health disorder, craziness, and the fall of a civil rights activist into being an Uncle Tom.

Furthermore, as a response to media backlash and rumors, Kanye sought seclusion on a 4,000-acre Wyoming ranch where he could escape the public and create music. Seeking a way to deal with bipolar issues stigmatized by the media, he sought to develop a way for the press and fans to understand his complications. These conditions created *ye*, an album that delves deeply

into Kanye's personal experiences and emotions, addressing themes such as his relationships with suicide, drugs, sex, loyalty, fatherhood, and freedom. The album offers a raw, personal scrutiny of how Kanye sees himself both in the public sphere and in his private life as a father. Generally, critics called *ye* a chaotic album, reflecting the turbulent times in which Kanye found himself. But in this chaos, "Ghost Town" feels like it encapsulates all of this chaos and relates it to how Kanye made sense of it and moved forward.

Firstly, "Ghost Town" begins with a soul sample from Kanye's childhood, a snippet from Shirley Ann Lee's 1960s soul song "Someday." Shirley Ann Lee's yearning for a perfect world and redemption is characterized by her lyrics "Someday I'll, I wanna wear a starry crown." Evoking comparisons to wearing a starry crown, Shirley Ann Lee references a Revelation Bible verse that describes a woman bringing in a new world. This longing for a better future resonates with Kanye's quest for freedom and redemption.

Next, PARTYNEXTDOOR's verse transforms this biblical idea of God resting on the seventh day into his concept of freedom, singing, "I wanna lay down, like God did, on Sunday." This line reflects the desire to be free from burdens and responsibilities, equating freedom with a state of rest and peace. As he continues, "Every day I'm livin' high, I do whatever I wanna, oh, yeah," Party equates freedom with the euphoria of living without constraints, a theme that runs throughout the song.

Following Party's verse, Kid Cudi sings an interpolation of Royal Jester's 1967 song "Take Me For a Little While" a song that yearns for the love of a former lover. Using the lyrics, "I've been tryin' to make you love me" is a representation of how freedom is yearned for. After this line, Cudi continues to interpolate, saying "But everything I try just takes you further from me." This line of thinking feels like Cudi is being locked into this relationship, and freedom feels further and further away.

Then, Kanye follows Cudi's bridge with his verse, discussing personal struggles in the media and what it means for his family. He starts by promising himself and his family, "Someday the drama'll be gone, And they'll play this song on and on." This promise counters Kid Cudi's doubts that freedom is too far away, instead claiming that freedom is within reach and will eventually become a reality. He acknowledges that he must overcome his challenges with mental health, saying, "Sometimes I take all the shine, Talk like I drank all the wine." Apologizing for his situation, he acknowledges what he needs to do to become free, but remains hopeful that he will have freedom someday. Finishing his verse with the words, "This not what they had in mind, But maybe someday."

Subsequently, Kid Cudi's bridge plays again, with 070 Shake gallantly charging her vocals into the outro. Shake proclaims, "And nothing hurts anymore, I feel kinda free." Her voice, filled with raw emotion, brings a sense of relief to the pain and struggle Cudi and Kanye discussed. This declaration of newfound freedom and release from pain underscores the central theme of the track—finding liberation from the struggles and pressures of life.

Finally, the instrumentation content in "Ghost Town" truly brings together the feeling of freedom in the song. The song follows a consistent sample of the song Kid Cudi was interpolating, "Take Me For a Little While." Using the same bass, keys, and drums, it is a consistent loop that does not get tiring after many listens. On top of the "Take Me For a Little While" sample, Kanye incorporates an electric guitar following the vocals of all artists featured on the song besides Kanye's verse, making the impact of their lyrics even greater. Using a riser sound effect at the start of Kanye's verse, it sounds like a firework soaring into the sky, alluding to Kanye's verse being an explosion. Instrumentation in 070 Shake's outro is especially poignant, as it uses only a drum and bass at some points, but includes sci-fi sound effects and other

instruments elements to convey the feeling of freedom and isolation, also adding to the power of her vocals.

Thus, Kanye's "Ghost Town" reflects his need to be free, bringing multiple different artists to help decipher his own feelings of freedom. Exploring the first stages of childhood and what it Kanye felt like listening to music as a child through the lens of Shirley Ann Lee's "Someday." PARTYNEXTDOOR's verse discusses Kanye's platform being able to do whatever he wants to do, hence "Every day I'm livin' high, I do whatever I wanna, oh, yeah." But despite his own freedom to say and do whatever he wants, Kid Cudi's bridge explains that what Kanye feels will bring him freedom will continue to keep him away from true freedom. Kanye rebukes this, instead continuing to do what he does best, making promises and "talk like I drank all the wine." Recognizing that this is not the lifestyle that will grant him freedom, Cudi's bridge plays again. Reflecting, Kanye communicates through 070 Shake's outro, stating that freedom is ultimately a state of emotional release and peace. Shake's powerful declaration, "And nothing hurts anymore, I feel kinda free," embodies the culmination of Kanye's journey through his internal struggles and the pursuit of liberation. Still today, Kanye is still on this journey for freedom, continuing to say outlandish things and a constant change in wanting in the spotlight and being a hermit.

In conclusion, Kanye West's "Ghost Town," is a thoughtful discussion of what freedom means. Kanye West encapsulates the act of taking the burdens of life and the idea of youthfulness into the meaning of freedom. "Ghost Town"'s reflective lyrics about Kanye's actions, the meaningful Shirley Ann Lee sample, and the guitar sample perfectly consider how freedom is viewed. Bringing us on a journey through his mind, as well as guiding the listener, freedom is truly encapsulated in "Ghost Town." Through "Ghost Town" Kanye connects to what it means to be anti, to truly bring the listener into the state of mind of finding freedom in an imperfect soul.

Peer Reviews: [Josue](#) [Santiago](#)